

AI prompts for IT support work

A companion handout · use these to work faster, not to skip learning

Read this first

AI will not troubleshoot for you. It cannot see the machine, it does not know what the user actually did, and it will state wrong answers with total confidence. What it is genuinely good at is the work *around* troubleshooting: reading long logs, drafting scripts, explaining unfamiliar errors, and turning a fix into a note a non-technical person can understand.

Three rules that keep you employable. Never run a script you cannot read line by line. Never paste customer data, passwords, licence keys or internal hostnames into a public AI tool. Always verify anything factual against vendor documentation before you act on it.

Diagnosing

Decode an unfamiliar error

Stop codes and event IDs are deliberately terse. Ask for plain language plus an ordered plan, safest step first, so you are not tempted to jump to the destructive option.

I have a Windows stop code 0x0000007E that started after installing a display driver. Explain the likely cause in plain language, then give me three checks in the order I should try them, safest first. Tell me what each check rules in or out.

Make sense of a long log

This is where AI earns its place. Paste the log, ask for patterns and timestamps, then go and confirm the interesting lines yourself.

Here is a Windows System event log excerpt. Group the errors by likely root cause, flag anything that repeats on a schedule, and tell me which three entries I should investigate first and why. Do not guess at causes you cannot support from the log itself.

Pressure-test your own theory

The most valuable prompt on this page. It forces you to defend a diagnosis before you act on it, which is exactly what a senior tech would make you do.

I think this machine's random shutdowns are caused by overheating. Here is what I have observed: [describe]. Argue against my theory. What else could produce these symptoms, and what single test would distinguish between the possibilities?

Automating

Draft a read-only triage script

Asking for comments on every line turns the script into a lesson. Asking for read-only means a mistake cannot damage anything.

```
Write a PowerShell script that reports free disk space,
the top 5 processes by memory, and the last 5 System
event log errors. Add a comment above every line
explaining what it does. The script must be read-only
and must not change any system setting.
```

Explain a script somebody handed you

You will inherit scripts. Never run one you do not understand, and never let AI's summary be your only check.

```
Explain this PowerShell script line by line for someone
new to scripting. Flag anything that modifies the system,
deletes data, or needs administrator rights. Tell me what
would happen if I ran it on the wrong machine.
```

Communicating

Turn a fix into a ticket note

Clear documentation is a large part of how you get promoted off the help desk. This prompt makes it a thirty-second job.

```
Write a 3-sentence ticket resolution note for a
non-technical user. Cover the cause, what I did, and what
they should watch for. No jargon. Here is what happened:
[describe].
```

Explain something to a frustrated user

Tone matters more than accuracy when someone has lost work. Ask for the version that acknowledges the frustration without over-apologising.

```
Rewrite this explanation for a user who is stressed and
not technical. Be direct about what happened and what
happens next. Do not over-apologise and do not use
technical terms without explaining them: [paste].
```

Studying

Get quizzed, not lectured

Passive reading feels productive and is not. Being asked questions you cannot answer is how you find your real gaps.

Quiz me on CompTIA A+ Windows troubleshooting. Ask one question at a time and wait for my answer. If I get it wrong, do not just correct me. Ask a simpler question that helps me work out where my thinking broke.

Build the mental model

If you can only recite a definition you will fail the scenario questions. Analogies are how you get to understanding.

Explain the difference between chkdsk and S.M.A.R.T. using an everyday analogy, then give me a realistic help desk scenario where choosing the wrong one would waste hours.

Where AI is still wrong

- It invents PowerShell cmdlets and registry paths that sound right and do not exist.
- It gives Windows 10 steps for Windows 11 and does not tell you which version it assumed.
- It will confidently recommend a reset when a restore would have worked.
- It has no idea what the user actually did, and the user is usually the missing variable.

Use it as a fast, well-read colleague who is sometimes wrong and never says so. You are still the technician. The judgement, and the responsibility, stay with you.